NCE EXAM PREP

Practice Exam 22

Domain 4

Provision of Counseling Interventions

34 Practice Questions | 45 minutes

A, B, C answer choices

Answer Key and Explanations included

> **Instructions.** Select the single best answer for each question. Record your answers separately. This domain practice set is drawn from Full-Length Practice Exam 04. Use the suggested 45-minute practice timer. Do not consult Part B until you complete Part A. These domain timings are editorial practice allocations, not official NBCC section limits.

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PART A — QUESTIONS

Choose one answer (A, B, or C) per question.

Question 1

> A client sends the counselor a friend request on a personal social-media account. Agency policy prohibits online personal connections with current clients. The client later asks why the request was not accepted.

How should the counselor respond?

A) Accept the request temporarily so the client does not experience rejection.

B) State only that agency policy forbids it and move to another topic.

C) Explain the boundary, invite discussion of the meaning or impact, and identify appropriate channels for therapeutic contact.

Question 2

> A client rarely makes eye contact. A previous counselor called the behavior resistant, but the client explains that sustained eye contact with an authority figure feels disrespectful in the client's family and cultural context.

How should the current counselor respond?

A) Use direct eye contact consistently so the client becomes comfortable with standard counseling behavior.

B) Avoid looking at the client at all because any eye contact may be culturally inappropriate.

C) Accept the client's explanation and collaboratively identify nonverbal ways of communicating attention that feel comfortable.

Question 3

> A high school student's friend died from an overdose. The student says, "I should grieve the way everyone else is, but I sometimes feel angry and sometimes feel normal." The student is safe and has supportive adults available.

What is the counselor's best response?

A) Normalize variation in grief reactions and help the student choose supportive people and a personally meaningful way to remember the friend.

B) Encourage the student to attend every peer memorial activity so grief can be shared consistently.

C) Explain that feeling normal indicates the student is avoiding the loss.

Question 4

A client's spouse has been unexpectedly detained by immigration authorities. The client is safe but overwhelmed, distrusts unfamiliar agencies, and wants help deciding whom to contact. The counselor is not qualified to give legal advice.

What should the counselor do?

A) Interpret the distrust as a stress reaction and encourage contact with the nearest government office.

B) Give the client a specific prediction about the spouse's legal outcome to reduce uncertainty.

C) Help the client identify a trusted support person and a reputable qualified legal resource while preserving the client's choice about contact.

Question 5

The counselor interrupts a client's account with an interpretation. The client loses the train of thought and says, "Never mind. It probably wasn't important."

What is the counselor's best response?

A) Acknowledge the interruption, set aside the interpretation, and invite the client to resume at the client's pace.

B) Explain the interpretation more fully so the client understands why the interruption was necessary.

C) Move to another topic because asking the client to reconstruct the thought may create pressure.

Question 6

A client considering two job offers repeatedly asks, "Just tell me which one you would choose." The client has already identified meaningful advantages and costs of both options.

What is the counselor's best response?

A) Acknowledge the wish for certainty and help the client weigh the options against the client's own priorities.

B) Choose the offer with greater stability because the client is requesting direct guidance.

C) Refuse to discuss either offer because counselors should never participate in client decisions.

Question 7

A client reports hearing a voice saying that neighbors are watching. The counselor has established that the voice gives no harmful commands, the client has no intent to harm self or others, and the client can engage in conversation while additional clinical support is arranged.

What is the counselor's best immediate response?

A) Acknowledge that the experience is frightening, avoid confirming the belief about neighbors, and help the client orient to the present setting.

B) Agree that the neighbors may be watching so the client feels understood.

C) Argue that the voice is not real until the client accepts the counselor's explanation.

Question 8

Which sequence most closely reflects an effective general crisis-intervention approach?

A) Detailed processing, interpretation of meaning, then assessment of immediate needs.

B) Establish safety and stabilization, address practical needs and coping, then mobilize supports and follow-up.

C) Provide reassurance, avoid discussing choices, then wait for spontaneous recovery.

Question 9

> A Muslim client in an intensive outpatient program wants to participate fully but notes that one skills group overlaps a daily prayer time. The program can move the client to an equivalent group offered later.

What is the counselor's best response?

A) Explain that treatment routines should remain separate from religious practices.

B) Explore the client's preference and arrange the equivalent group if the client chooses it.

C) Encourage the client to miss prayer during treatment because clinical attendance has priority.

Question 10

> A client assumes a friend's delayed reply means, "She is angry and ending the friendship." The client recognizes that several explanations are possible but cannot think of any during moments of distress.

Which intervention is most appropriate?

A) Advise the client to send repeated messages until the friend clarifies the delay.

B) Tell the client that delayed replies usually mean nothing and should be ignored.

C) Practice generating multiple plausible explanations and identifying what evidence would distinguish among them.

Question 11

> As planned termination approaches, a client says, "If counseling ends, it means you never really cared." The client has made substantial progress, and no clinical need for indefinite treatment has been identified.

What is the counselor's best response?

A) Cancel termination so the client does not experience the ending as abandonment.

B) Explore the meaning of ending, review the relationship and progress, and collaborate on a deliberate closure process.

C) Emphasize that professional relationships must end and avoid discussing personal feelings about it.

Question 12

> A client feels pulled between a personally meaningful creative career and a higher-paying profession strongly preferred by family. The client does not want the counselor to decide but wants greater clarity.

Which intervention best fits the client's request?

A) Guide a values-clarification exercise and compare how each option aligns with the client's chosen values and responsibilities.

B) Recommend the higher-paying option because financial stability reduces future stress.

C) Advise following the creative path because authentic choices should be independent of family influence.

Question 13

> A client with low vision wants to track situations, emotions, and coping responses but cannot use the standard printed diary. The client is comfortable recording short audio notes on a secure personal device.

How should the counselor proceed?

A) Ask a family member to complete the printed diary for the client.

B) Skip self-monitoring because changing the format would reduce its reliability.

C) Create an accessible audio structure that tracks the same targets and review whether it is useful to the client.

Question 14

> One partner says that sexual activity is expected after an expensive date. The other partner says this creates pressure and sometimes agrees to avoid conflict. Both ask the counselor to help them communicate.

What should the counselor emphasize first in the intervention?

A) Couples should compromise on frequency so neither partner feels rejected.

B) The pressured partner should be more direct before the date begins.

C) Consent must be freely given each time, after which the couple can practice communicating desire, refusal, and disappointment without coercion.

Question 15

> A client comes to counseling shortly after a miscarriage. Medical care is complete, and the client is physically safe but says, "Everyone acts as if this was nothing. I don't know whether I'm allowed to grieve."

Which counselor response is most appropriate?

A) Validate the significance of the loss, invite the client's own meaning, and explore desired support or remembrance.

B) Explain that grief is less intense when a loss occurs early in pregnancy.

C) Redirect the client toward future pregnancy plans to restore hope.

Question 16

> The counselor reflects, “You sound sad about your adult child moving away.” The client replies, “Not sad—relieved. I’ve felt responsible for everything for years.”

What is the counselor’s best response?

A) Explain that sadness often appears later after a major family transition.

B) Accept the correction and explore the client’s experience of relief and prolonged responsibility.

C) Ask whether relief is masking guilt about wanting the child to leave.

Question 17

> An older adult client wants an adult daughter involved in selected counseling sessions but does not want the daughter to receive all treatment information. The client has decision-making capacity and asks how to structure the involvement.

What should the counselor do?

A) Include the daughter in every session because family involvement is generally beneficial for older adults.

B) Clarify the client’s goals, specify what may be shared, and revisit consent as the daughter’s role changes.

C) Exclude the daughter to protect confidentiality from becoming complicated.

Question 18

> After receiving one critical comment on an otherwise positive evaluation, a client concludes, “This proves I fail at everything.” The client is willing to examine the conclusion.

Which intervention best applies guided discovery?

A) Tell the client that the conclusion is clearly irrational and should be discarded.

B) Reassure the client that the evaluator probably did not mean the criticism seriously.

C) Ask questions that compare the conclusion with the full evaluation and help the client develop a more balanced interpretation.

Question 19

> A client with sensory sensitivity finds the counseling room’s bright lights and background hum so distracting that a relaxation exercise becomes impossible. The office has adjustable lighting and a quieter room available.

What should the counselor do?

A) Continue the exercise so the client learns to relax under ordinary environmental conditions.

B) Collaboratively reduce the sensory load and repeat the exercise in a setting the client can use effectively.

C) Discontinue all relaxation work because sensory sensitivity makes it inappropriate.

Question 20

> After an apartment burglary, a client is physically safe but cannot decide whether to stay with a friend or return home after the locks are changed. The client asks the counselor to decide.

Which response best supports crisis recovery?

A) Recommend staying elsewhere because returning home too soon may worsen fear.

B) Review the verified safety information, explore what each option would provide, and support the client in choosing the next step.

C) Recommend immediate return so avoidance does not become established.

Question 21

What is the primary purpose of self-monitoring before modifying a recurring behavior?

A) To identify patterns among triggers, responses, and consequences that can guide intervention.

B) To prove that the client lacks sufficient willpower to stop the behavior.

C) To eliminate the behavior through observation alone.

Question 22

When is counselor self-disclosure most likely to be therapeutically appropriate?

A) When it reduces the counselor's discomfort with silence.

B) When it allows the counselor to demonstrate having more serious problems than the client.

C) When it is brief, serves a clear client-centered purpose, and its effect on the client is monitored.

Question 23

> A group member posts online, "Powerful stories in group tonight," without naming anyone. Another member says the post felt identifying because coworkers knew both people attended the group.

What should the leader do?

A) Dismiss the concern because no name or specific story appeared in the post.

B) Revisit the group's no-posting agreement, explore the impact, and facilitate accountability and repair.

C) Require the concerned member to leave social media so future posts cannot be seen.

Question 24

> In family counseling, a parent says a 12-year-old's stomachaches "cause all our arguments." The counselor notices that when the stomachaches are discussed, the parents stop criticizing each other and become briefly cooperative.

Which intervention would best expand the family's awareness?

A) Ask each family member how interactions change before, during, and after the child reports a stomachache.

B) Explain that the child is unconsciously producing symptoms to keep the parents together.

C) Focus only on eliminating the stomachaches before addressing family interaction.

Question 25

Which group-leader statement is the clearest example of process commentary?

A) "Today we will discuss coping with changes in employment."

B) "Several of you reported similar sleep difficulties this week."

C) "As disagreement increases, I notice members are directing comments to me instead of to one another."

Question 26

Which question is the best example of an open invitation without embedded advice?

A) "Where would it be most useful for us to begin today?"

B) "Have you considered setting firmer limits with your sister?"

C) "Did the disagreement happen before or after dinner?"

Question 27

> During the first meeting of a support group, members press a newcomer to disclose details of a traumatic event. The newcomer says, "I'm not ready," but another member replies, "You have to open up for group to work."

What should the leader do?

A) Encourage a brief disclosure so the newcomer can experience group support.

B) Reinforce the newcomer's right to choose the pace and invite discussion of how pressure affects safety in the group.

C) End discussion of trauma for all members until the newcomer is ready.

Question 28

> An adult family member uses an augmentative and alternative communication device. During family counseling, relatives answer questions before the person finishes composing responses. The device user looks frustrated and asks for more time.

What should the counselor do?

A) Ask relatives to summarize what the device user probably intended so the session can stay on schedule.

B) Address the device user directly, protect adequate response time, and ask what communication support is preferred.

C) Limit questions to yes-or-no choices because longer responses slow the family process.

Question 29

> The counselor yawns during a session. The client immediately stops and says, “I knew my problems were boring you.” The counselor is tired but had remained interested in the client’s account.

How should the counselor respond?

A) Explain that yawning is an involuntary physical reaction and has no interpersonal meaning.

B) Acknowledge how the yawn appeared, clarify the counselor’s interest without defensiveness, and invite the client’s reaction.

C) Ignore the comment and ask the client to continue so the session remains focused.

Question 30

> A client quickly agrees with every counselor suggestion but later says none of the suggestions fit. The counselor notices the client pause and tense before saying yes again.

Which response is most therapeutic?

A) “I notice a pause before you agree with me, and later the ideas do not fit. What is it like to disagree with me here?”

B) “I need you to be more honest when I offer a suggestion.”

C) “Let’s avoid suggestions so you will not feel pressured to agree.”

Question 31

> A client with chronic muscle tension wants to learn a body-based coping skill. The client has no medical limitation affecting the exercise and prefers learning by practicing during the session.

How should the counselor introduce progressive muscle relaxation?

A) Model tensing and releasing one muscle group, guide brief practice, and ask the client to notice and report the effect.

B) Provide written instructions and wait until the next session to discuss whether the client tried them.

C) Ask the client to tense every muscle as strongly as possible for several minutes before releasing.

Question 32

> A client makes impulsive online purchases when feeling lonely and regrets them the next day. The client wants a practical way to create time between the urge and the purchase.

Which intervention best matches the goal?

A) Ask the client to analyze advertisements for manipulative content after each purchase.

B) Advise the client to rely on stronger self-discipline when loneliness occurs.

C) Rehearse a delay routine, remove stored payment information, and track what happens to the urge during the waiting period.

Question 33

> A client reports an urge to engage in nonsuicidal self-injury after an argument. A current risk assessment finds no suicidal intent or plan, and the client is willing to use coping supports until the urge passes.

Which in-session intervention is most appropriate?

A) Ask the client to promise never to self-injure again.

B) Analyze the childhood origin of self-injury before discussing current coping.

C) Collaboratively reduce access to the intended method, rehearse a tolerable alternative, and identify a support contact.

Question 34

> A member arrives at a therapy group smelling strongly of alcohol, has slurred speech, and cannot follow the discussion. The written group agreement states that impaired members cannot participate and that staff will help arrange safe transportation.

What should the group leader do?

A) Speak with the member privately, apply the agreement, and arrange safe transportation while preserving dignity.

B) Allow the member to observe silently because removing the member could feel rejecting.

C) Ask the group to vote on whether the member may remain for this session.

PART B — ANSWER KEY AND EXPLANATIONS

Answers match the numbered items in Part A.

Question 1 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Explain the boundary, invite discussion of the meaning or impact, and identify appropriate channels for therapeutic contact.

Explanation: The counselor follows policy while recognizing that a declined request may carry relational meaning for the client. A policy-only response can feel abrupt, whereas accepting the request violates the established boundary.

Question 2 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Accept the client's explanation and collaboratively identify nonverbal ways of communicating attention that feel comfortable.

Explanation: The counselor uses the client's stated cultural meaning rather than treating a culturally congruent behavior as resistance. Collaboration avoids both imposing sustained gaze and stereotyping the client as unable to tolerate any eye contact.

Question 3 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Normalize variation in grief reactions and help the student choose supportive people and a personally meaningful way to remember the friend.

Explanation: Grief can include shifting and even apparently ordinary emotions, so the student does not need to match peers' responses. Client-chosen support and remembrance are more responsive than mandatory participation in every group ritual.

Question 4 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Help the client identify a trusted support person and a reputable qualified legal resource while preserving the client's choice about contact.

Explanation: The counselor remains within scope while supporting practical connection and the client's control over whom to trust. Predicting legal outcomes exceeds competence, and directing contact with a distrusted agency may reduce engagement.

Question 5 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Acknowledge the interruption, set aside the interpretation, and invite the client to resume at the client's pace.

Explanation: The counselor repairs the immediate disruption and returns ownership of the narrative to the client. Defending the interpretation would repeat the prioritization of counselor meaning over the client's developing account.

Question 6 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Acknowledge the wish for certainty and help the client weigh the options against the client's own priorities.

Explanation: The counselor responds to the client's uncertainty while supporting self-determined decision making. Choosing for the client would replace the client's values with the counselor's judgment, while refusing discussion would withhold useful decision support.

Question 7 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Acknowledge that the experience is frightening, avoid confirming the belief about neighbors, and help the client orient to the present setting.

Explanation: The counselor validates emotional distress without reinforcing unverified perceptual content and supports present engagement while further care is arranged. Arguing about reality can increase mistrust, while agreement strengthens the belief.

Question 8 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Establish safety and stabilization, address practical needs and coping, then mobilize supports and follow-up.

Explanation: Crisis intervention generally moves from immediate safety and stabilization toward manageable action, coping, and support continuity. Detailed meaning-making before immediate needs reverses the order in which a highly stressed person can often use help.

Question 9 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Explore the client's preference and arrange the equivalent group if the client chooses it.

Explanation: An available equivalent group allows full treatment participation while respecting a religious practice important to the client. Collaborative accommodation is more responsive than imposing a false choice between faith and care.

Question 10 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Practice generating multiple plausible explanations and identifying what evidence would distinguish among them.

Explanation: Generating alternatives weakens automatic mind reading without insisting on an unrealistically positive conclusion. Repeated messages may intensify the interpersonal problem, while generic reassurance does not build the client's ability to evaluate interpretations.

Question 11 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Explore the meaning of ending, review the relationship and progress, and collaborate on a deliberate closure process.

Explanation: Planned termination can be used to process attachment, loss, achievement, and future support rather than enacted as abandonment. Indefinite extension avoids the meaning of the ending, while a purely procedural response dismisses the client's relational concern.

Question 12 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Guide a values-clarification exercise and compare how each option aligns with the client's chosen values and responsibilities.

Explanation: Values clarification supports thoughtful choice without erasing either personal meaning or family responsibility. Recommending one path would impose the counselor's assumptions about security or authenticity.

Question 13 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Create an accessible audio structure that tracks the same targets and review whether it is useful to the client.

Explanation: Preserving the intervention's functional targets in an accessible format supports independent participation. Having a family member record private material reduces autonomy, while format adaptation does not inherently undermine useful self-monitoring.

Question 14 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Consent must be freely given each time, after which the couple can practice communicating desire, refusal, and disappointment without coercion.

Explanation: An expensive date does not create sexual obligation, and coerced agreement is not a basis for negotiated frequency. Establishing freely given consent is necessary before communication practice can be safe and meaningful.

Question 15 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Validate the significance of the loss, invite the client's own meaning, and explore desired support or remembrance.

Explanation: Miscarriage may carry profound and socially unrecognized grief, so the counselor should validate without prescribing what the loss must mean. Minimizing the loss or shifting prematurely to future pregnancy bypasses the client's current experience.

Question 16 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Accept the correction and explore the client's experience of relief and prolonged responsibility.

Explanation: Clients remain the authority on their emotional experience, and the correction opens an important theme of burden and release. Predicting hidden sadness or guilt would replace the client's stated feeling with the counselor's assumption.

Question 17 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Clarify the client's goals, specify what may be shared, and revisit consent as the daughter's role changes.

Explanation: The capable client determines the scope of family involvement and information sharing. Consent can be specific and revisited, avoiding both automatic inclusion and unnecessary exclusion.

Question 18 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Ask questions that compare the conclusion with the full evaluation and help the client develop a more balanced interpretation.

Explanation: Guided discovery uses collaborative questions and available evidence to help the client form a more complete conclusion. Directly labeling the belief irrational or offering reassurance makes the counselor the source of correction rather than building the client's reasoning skill.

Question 19 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Collaboratively reduce the sensory load and repeat the exercise in a setting the client can use effectively.

Explanation: Modifying preventable environmental barriers allows the client to learn the intended skill under usable conditions. Forcing practice in an overwhelming room tests sensory tolerance rather than teaching relaxation.

Question 20 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Review the verified safety information, explore what each option would provide, and support the client in choosing the next step.

Explanation: The intervention grounds the decision in current safety facts while preserving the client's agency after a violation of personal security. Automatically prescribing either avoidance or immediate return substitutes a general rule for the client's needs and readiness.

Question 21 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: To identify patterns among triggers, responses, and consequences that can guide intervention.

Explanation: Self-monitoring provides data about when and how a behavior occurs so intervention can target relevant cues and maintaining consequences. Observation may influence behavior, but it does not guarantee elimination and is not a test of willpower.

Question 22 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: When it is brief, serves a clear client-centered purpose, and its effect on the client is monitored.

Explanation: Therapeutic self-disclosure is used selectively for the client's benefit and followed by attention to how the client receives it. Disclosure intended to relieve the counselor or compete with the client reverses the focus of counseling.

Question 23 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Revisit the group's no-posting agreement, explore the impact, and facilitate accountability and repair.

Explanation: Even a vague post can feel identifying within overlapping social networks, so the leader addresses both the agreement and relational harm. Dismissing the concern based only on omitted names ignores contextual identifiability.

Question 24 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Ask each family member how interactions change before, during, and after the child reports a stomachache.

Explanation: Circular exploration helps the family observe reciprocal patterns without declaring that the child intentionally causes or controls them. Focusing only on symptom removal would miss how family interactions may organize around the symptom.

Question 25 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: “As disagreement increases, I notice members are directing comments to me instead of to one another.”

Explanation: Process commentary describes an observable here-and-now interaction pattern for the group to examine. Naming a session topic or summarizing similar content does not address how members are relating in the moment.

Question 26 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: “Where would it be most useful for us to begin today?”

Explanation: This question invites a broad client-directed response without suggesting a preferred solution. The other questions either embed advice or request a narrowly defined fact.

Question 27 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Reinforce the newcomer’s right to choose the pace and invite discussion of how pressure affects safety in the group.

Explanation: The leader protects autonomy and turns the pressure itself into relevant group-process material. Requiring even a brief disclosure violates the expressed boundary, while banning trauma discussion for everyone is unnecessarily broad.

Question 28 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Address the device user directly, protect adequate response time, and ask what communication support is preferred.

Explanation: The device user remains the primary participant and should control how communication is supported. Having relatives speak for the person or limiting expression to yes-or-no responses unnecessarily reduces autonomy and nuance.

Question 29 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Acknowledge how the yawn appeared, clarify the counselor’s interest without defensiveness, and invite the client’s reaction.

Explanation: The counselor addresses the interpersonal impact of an involuntary behavior instead of arguing that it should have no meaning. Ignoring the client’s interpretation would leave a clear alliance concern unresolved.

Question 30 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: “I notice a pause before you agree with me, and later the ideas do not fit. What is it like to disagree with me here?”

Explanation: The counselor uses a tentative here-and-now observation to explore compliance within the therapeutic relationship. Accusing the client of dishonesty is judgmental, while eliminating all suggestions avoids rather than examines the pattern.

Question 31 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Model tensing and releasing one muscle group, guide brief practice, and ask the client to notice and report the effect.

Explanation: Modeling, limited practice, and feedback allow the client to learn the contrast between tension and release safely and experientially. Maximum prolonged tension is unnecessary, and written instructions alone do not match the client’s preferred learning method.

Question 32 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Rehearse a delay routine, remove stored payment information, and track what happens to the urge during the waiting period.

Explanation: The intervention adds time and friction between urge and purchase while generating information about how urges change. Relying on willpower alone does not modify the environment or provide a practiced alternative.

Question 33 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Collaboratively reduce access to the intended method, rehearse a tolerable alternative, and identify a support contact.

Explanation: The intervention addresses the current urge through means reduction, practiced coping, and connection under the risk findings provided. A promise is not a functional coping plan, and historical analysis should not displace immediate harm-reduction work.

Question 34 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Speak with the member privately, apply the agreement, and arrange safe transportation while preserving dignity.

Explanation: The leader follows the known participation boundary and addresses the immediate safety need without publicly shaming the member. Group voting would transfer a clinical and policy responsibility to members, while silent observation does not resolve impairment.
